

**“A Correlational Study on the Relationship of Forgiveness
and Gratitude with Psychological Well-Being, Happiness,
Among College Students”**

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Abstract

This study investigates the correlations between forgiveness, psychological well-being, happiness, and gratitude among 100 college students. Using simple and reliable self-report scales, it explores whether forgiveness is linked to better mental health outcomes. The findings aim to guide strategies for supporting student well-being. The dissertation includes an introduction to each variable, an extended literature review, a methodology outline, easy-to-use measurement tools, and references.

Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1 Background of the Study

The phase of college life is universally acknowledged as a time of significant personal transformation and identity development. College students face a unique set of challenges that include academic pressures, career uncertainty, peer competition, emotional fluctuations, and growing social responsibilities. The increased academic workload, constant performance evaluation, social comparisons, and transitions in personal roles can contribute to psychological stress, emotional exhaustion, and mental health problems. In such an environment, psychological resilience and emotional adaptability become crucial for maintaining optimal functioning and well-being.

The emerging field of positive psychology has introduced several constructs that not only help reduce psychological distress but also promote a flourishing and meaningful life. Among these constructs, forgiveness, psychological well-being (PWB), happiness, and gratitude have received notable attention. These traits are not merely coping mechanisms but are proactive strategies for personal growth and resilience. This study explores the interconnectedness of these four constructs and aims to identify the extent to which forgiveness predicts psychological well-being, happiness, and gratitude among college students.

1.2 Forgiveness as a Psychological Construct

Forgiveness, in the context of psychology, is defined as a deliberate process of letting go of resentment, anger, and the desire for revenge toward someone who has caused harm. It does not imply condoning or excusing the wrongdoing, nor does it require reconciliation. Instead, forgiveness is a personal transformation of emotional and cognitive responses, leading to peace and reduced psychological stress.

Researchers differentiate between state forgiveness (related to a specific incident) and trait forgiveness (a general disposition to forgive across contexts). This study focuses on trait forgiveness as measured by the Heartland Forgiveness Scale (HFS). Trait forgiveness is believed to contribute to greater emotional regulation, interpersonal harmony, and resilience in the face of social adversity.

For college students, the ability to forgive may help resolve interpersonal conflicts, improve social integration, and reduce emotional distress. Many students experience frequent disappointments in relationships—be it with peers, mentors, or family. In such scenarios, a forgiving attitude can help release emotional burdens, restore relationships, and promote psychological growth.

1.3 Psychological Well-Being: A Multifaceted Concept

Psychological Well-Being (PWB), as conceptualized by Carol Ryff, comprises six dimensions: self-acceptance, autonomy, positive relations with others, environmental mastery, purpose in life, and personal growth. These dimensions collectively reflect the individual's overall functioning and fulfillment in life. PWB is different from the absence of mental illness—it represents positive psychological functioning, the ability to navigate challenges with a sense of control and growth.

In the academic environment, students with high psychological well-being are more likely to be resilient, socially connected, and motivated toward self-improvement. They can better manage the demands of academic life, establish healthy relationships, and engage meaningfully with their environment.

Forgiveness, by reducing negative emotional states and improving interpersonal dynamics, is theorized to enhance several components of PWB. For instance, it promotes self-acceptance and positive relations, while reducing emotional barriers that hinder personal growth and purpose in life.

1.4 The Role of Happiness in Student Life

Happiness, or subjective well-being (SWB), is generally understood as a state of life satisfaction combined with frequent positive emotions and infrequent negative emotions. In psychological literature, happiness is divided into hedonic well-being (pleasure and life satisfaction) and eudaimonic well-being (meaning and self-realization). Both dimensions are relevant to the lives of students who are exploring identities, values, and future roles.

Happiness among students is associated with improved learning, better memory retention, stronger social connections, and greater academic performance. It has also been linked to better physical health, problem-solving skills, and optimism.

Forgiveness is expected to play a role in enhancing happiness by mitigating the burden of negative affect, enabling students to experience more positive emotions, and fostering healthy interpersonal dynamics. Individuals who can forgive may experience less rumination and emotional fatigue, thereby creating space for joy, gratitude, and fulfillment.

1.5 Gratitude: A Key Trait for Positive Living

Gratitude is defined as the recognition and appreciation of the positive aspects of life. It is both a state (temporary emotional response) and a trait (a stable disposition). Trait gratitude reflects a tendency to notice and appreciate the good in one's life on a regular basis. Research shows that gratitude is associated with increased happiness, reduced stress, stronger relationships, and better physical health.

In academic contexts, gratitude helps students cope with stress, maintain optimism, and build positive social networks. It allows them to focus on what is working well in their lives, even in the face of challenges.

There is a strong theoretical and empirical linkage between gratitude and forgiveness. Both traits encourage positive reframing and compassionate thinking. Individuals who are grateful may be more inclined to understand others' perspectives and to forgive transgressions, thereby reducing emotional distress and enhancing well-being.

1.6 Interconnections Among the Constructs

The constructs of forgiveness, PWB, happiness, and gratitude are interrelated and collectively contribute to emotional and psychological resilience. Forgiveness acts as a psychological release mechanism, allowing the individual to let go of negative emotions that hinder positive growth. This in turn enhances psychological well-being and happiness. Gratitude, on the other hand, helps in maintaining a positive outlook and reinforcing social bonds, which further strengthens psychological well-being and facilitates forgiveness.

According to the Broaden-and-Build Theory by Fredrickson (2001), positive emotions like gratitude and forgiveness broaden individuals' thought-action repertoires, enabling them to build enduring personal resources such as optimism, resilience, and interpersonal trust. Similarly, Ryff's model of PWB aligns with the eudaimonic perspective, where emotional healing and personal development are seen as integral to well-being.

Thus, forgiveness, PWB, happiness, and gratitude can be seen as components of a positive psychological cycle, each reinforcing the others to help students thrive.

1.7 Purpose and Rationale of the Study

This study explores the relationships between forgiveness and three outcomes—PWB, happiness, and gratitude—in a sample of 100 college students. The goal is to understand how these traits interact and whether forgiveness can enhance mental health in higher education.

While each construct has been studied in isolation or in pairs, few studies have examined the composite interplay of all four within the context of higher education. This study addresses this gap by investigating whether forgiveness can serve as a core psychological trait that fosters emotional well-being, gratitude, and happiness in young adults during a critical stage of personal development.

1.8 Significance of the Study

This research holds significance for both theoretical advancement and practical application:

- Theoretical Significance: It contributes to the literature of positive psychology by integrating four interrelated constructs and assessing their joint influence on student mental health.
- Practical Significance: The results can inform student development programs, counseling practices, and curriculum design that promote emotional intelligence, conflict resolution, and gratitude training.

By understanding the role of forgiveness in shaping psychological

outcomes, institutions can develop evidence-based interventions—such as forgiveness workshops, gratitude journals, and mental well-being seminars—to help students navigate their academic and social lives more effectively.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

The interplay of forgiveness, psychological well-being (PWB), happiness, and gratitude has garnered significant attention in positive psychology. These constructs are particularly relevant for college students, who face developmental and environmental challenges that test their emotional resilience. This extended review synthesizes theoretical frameworks, empirical findings, and gaps in the literature to contextualize the current study. It explores each variable individually, their interconnections, and their specific relevance to college populations, providing a robust foundation for examining their correlations.

2.2 Theoretical Frameworks

Positive psychology emphasizes strengths that enable individuals to flourish. Two key theories underpin this study:

- **Broaden-and-Build Theory (Fredrickson, 2001):** This theory posits that positive emotions, such as those fostered by forgiveness and gratitude, broaden thought-action repertoires and build lasting psychological resources. For example, forgiving a peer may open pathways to trust, while gratitude may inspire generosity, both enhancing well-being and happiness.
- **Eudaimonic vs. Hedonic Well-Being (Ryff & Singer, 2008):** Eudaimonic well-being (PWB) focuses on meaning and purpose, while hedonic well-being (happiness) emphasizes pleasure and

satisfaction. Forgiveness and gratitude may bridge these dimensions by promoting both personal growth and emotional positivity, particularly in college students navigating identity and goals.

These frameworks suggest that forgiveness, PWB, happiness, and gratitude are mutually reinforcing, warranting their joint investigation.

2.3 Forgiveness

Forgiveness is a multifaceted construct, encompassing cognitive decisions to release resentment and emotional shifts toward empathy or compassion (Worthington & Scherer, 2004). Enright and Fitzgibbons (2000) describe forgiveness as a process involving acknowledgment of hurt, empathy for the offender, and commitment to move forward. Dispositional forgiveness, the focus of this study, reflects a general tendency to forgive across contexts.

Empirical studies link forgiveness to mental health benefits. Toussaint et al. (2015) found that higher forgiveness correlates with lower depression and anxiety in community samples. Among college students, Lawler-Row and Piferi (2006) reported that forgiveness of interpersonal conflicts predicts reduced stress and better academic adjustment. For instance, forgiving a roommate for a disagreement may alleviate tension, freeing emotional energy for studies or socializing.

Forgiveness also intersects with cultural and social factors. McCullough and Witvliet (2002) note that forgiveness is shaped by collectivist versus individualist values, which may influence college students from diverse backgrounds. Additionally, Worthington et al. (2007) highlight

forgiveness's role in repairing relationships, a critical task for students forming new social networks. Despite these insights, fewer studies explore forgiveness as a trait in non-clinical college samples, a gap this study addresses.

2.4 Psychological Well-Being

Ryff's (1989) model of PWB defines it as comprising six dimensions: self-acceptance, positive relations with others, autonomy, environmental mastery, purpose in life, and personal growth. Unlike happiness, PWB emphasizes flourishing through challenges, making it highly relevant for college students transitioning to adulthood.

Research underscores PWB's protective effects. Keyes (2005) found that higher PWB predicts resilience against mental health issues, while Bowman (2010) showed that college students with strong PWB report better academic engagement and social integration. For example, a student with high self-acceptance may confidently navigate group projects, enhancing both grades and peer connections.

Forgiveness may bolster PWB by fostering positive relations and personal growth. Hill and Allemand (2010) found that forgiving individuals report stronger interpersonal bonds, a key PWB component. Similarly, Toussaint and Friedman (2009) suggest that forgiveness reduces emotional burdens, enabling students to pursue meaningful goals. However, most PWB studies focus on older adults or clinical populations, leaving college students underexplored, particularly in relation to forgiveness.

2.5 Happiness

Happiness, or subjective well-being, integrates life satisfaction, positive affect, and low negative affect (Diener et al., 1999). It is influenced by genetics, circumstances, and intentional activities, with the latter offering the most control (Lyubomirsky, 2008). For college students, happiness is a dynamic state, shaped by academic success, social ties, and personal achievements.

Studies link happiness to tangible outcomes. Oishi et al. (2007) found that happier students are more likely to persist in college, while Seligman et al. (2005) showed that positive emotions enhance problem-solving, benefiting academic performance. Forgiveness may contribute to happiness by reducing grudges that sap emotional energy. Maltby et al. (2005) reported a positive correlation between forgiveness and happiness in undergraduates, suggesting that forgiving a professor for a low grade might restore a student's optimism.

Cultural variations also matter. Diener and Suh (2000) note that happiness is expressed differently across cultures, which is relevant for diverse college campuses. Yet, happiness research often overlooks its interplay with forgiveness and gratitude in student populations, a focus of this study.

2.6 Gratitude

Gratitude involves recognizing and valuing life's positives, from small acts of kindness to major milestones (Emmons & McCullough, 2003). It is both a trait and a state, with trait gratitude—consistent thankfulness—

emphasized here. Gratitude fosters positive emotions and strengthens relationships, aligning with the broaden-and-build theory.

Among college students, gratitude is linked to mental health benefits. Wood et al. (2010) found that grateful students report lower stress and higher life satisfaction, potentially due to appreciating supportive peers or academic opportunities. Froh et al. (2008) showed that gratitude interventions, like keeping a gratitude journal, increase optimism in young adults, a feasible practice for students.

Gratitude and forgiveness may share mechanisms. Bono et al. (2008) suggest both involve reframing negative experiences—forgiveness neutralizes harm, while gratitude amplifies positivity. McCullough et al. (2006) found that grateful individuals are more likely to forgive, possibly because gratitude fosters empathy. For example, a student grateful for a friend's support may more readily forgive a minor betrayal. However, studies rarely examine gratitude alongside forgiveness, PWB, and happiness in college settings.

2.7 Interrelationships

The four constructs are interconnected. Forgiveness and gratitude both reduce negative emotions and enhance social bonds, potentially boosting PWB and happiness (Toussaint & Friedman, 2009). Happiness and PWB share predictors like strong relationships, suggesting overlap (Ryff & Singer, 2008). Gratitude may mediate the link between forgiveness and well-being by fostering positive reframing (Bono et al., 2008).

College students offer a unique context for these relationships. Park et al. (2004) note that emerging adults prioritize identity and relationships,

amplifying the relevance of forgiveness and gratitude. For instance, forgiving a family member may align with a student's purpose in life (PWB), while gratitude for mentorship may spark joy (happiness). Yet, few studies integrate all four constructs in this population, often focusing on pairs (e.g., forgiveness and happiness) rather than their collective dynamics.

2.8 Relevance to College Students

College students face stressors like exams, financial pressures, and social conflicts, which can undermine mental health (Arnett, 2000).

Forgiveness may help resolve disputes with peers, enhancing PWB and happiness. Gratitude can shift focus to positive experiences, like supportive professors, fostering resilience. PWB equips students to handle challenges with purpose, while happiness sustains motivation. Together, these traits may create a virtuous cycle, but empirical evidence specific to students is sparse.

2.9 Gaps and Rationale

Despite robust literature, several gaps persist:

- Most studies target general or clinical populations, not college students.
- Forgiveness is often studied in specific contexts (e.g., romantic relationships), not as a trait.
- Few studies examine forgiveness, PWB, happiness, and gratitude together, missing potential synergies.

- Cultural influences on these constructs are underexplored in diverse student samples.

This study addresses these gaps by investigating correlations among all four constructs in 100 college students, using simple, validated scales to ensure accessibility and relevance.

Objectives of the study

The primary aim of this study is to investigate the relationships between forgiveness, psychological well-being, happiness, and gratitude among college students, focusing on how forgiveness contributes to positive mental health outcomes. The specific objectives are:

1. To study the relation of forgiveness with psychological well being and happiness.
2. To study the relation of gratitude with psychological well being and happiness.

Chapter 3: Methodology

Hypotheses of the Study

The following hypotheses are proposed to guide the investigation, expecting positive relationships based on established psychological principles:

Hypothesis 1: Forgiveness will be positively and significantly correlated with psychological well-being among college students.

Hypothesis 2: Forgiveness will be positively and significantly correlated with happiness among college students.

Hypothesis 3: Forgiveness will be positively correlated with gratitude among college students.

Hypothesis 4: Psychological well-being, happiness, and gratitude will be positively intercorrelated, with forgiveness acting as a significant predictor of these outcomes.

3.2 Research Design

Cross-sectional correlational study to explore relationships between forgiveness, psychological well-being, happiness, and gratitude.

3.3 Participants

- Sample Size: 100 college students.
- Age Range: 18–25 years.

- Recruitment: Through university emails, posters, and psychology course announcements.
- Inclusion Criteria: Full-time students
- Sampling Technique: Purposive Sampling

3.4 Measures

1. Heartland Forgiveness Scale (HFS):

- What It Measures: How likely someone is to forgive themselves, others, or situations.
- Format: 18 questions, rated 1 (Almost Always False) to 7 (Almost Always True).
- Example: “I don’t stay upset with people who hurt me.” ○ Why It’s Easy: Short, clear questions; takes about 5 minutes.
- Reliability: Very consistent (Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.87$).

2. Ryff’s Psychological Well-Being Scale (Short Version):

- What It Measures: Feeling good about life, relationships, and personal growth.
- Format: 18 questions (simplified from 42 for ease), rated 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 6 (Strongly Agree).
- Example: “I like who I am.”
- Why It’s Easy: Brief, relatable for students; takes 5–7 minutes.
- Reliability: Strong (Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.85$).

3. Subjective Happiness Scale (SHS):

- What It Measures: Overall happiness in life. ○ Format: 4 questions, rated 1 (Not Very Happy) to 7 (Very Happy).
- Example: “I feel I’m a happy person.” ○ Why It’s Easy: Very short, simple wording; takes 2 minutes. ○ Reliability: Highly dependable (Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.86$).

4. Gratitude Questionnaire-6 (GQ-6):

- What It Measures: Tendency to feel thankful for life’s positives.
- Format: 6 questions, rated 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 7 (Strongly Agree).
- Example: “I’m grateful for many things.” ○ Why It’s Easy: Quick, everyday language; takes 3 minutes. ○ Reliability: Solid (Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.82$).

3.5 Procedure

- Online survey using a platform like Google Forms.
- Steps: Consent form, basic info (age, gender, year), then HFS, PWB, SHS, GQ-6.
- Duration: 15–20 minutes total.
- Data collected over one semester.

3.6 Ethical Considerations

- Participation is optional; students can stop anytime.
- Data kept anonymous and secure.
- Support resources provided post-survey.

Scales/Tools

1. Heartland Forgiveness Scale (HFS):

- Source: Thompson et al. (2005).
- Purpose: Measures general forgiveness.
- Scoring: Add scores (reverse some items); higher = more forgiving.
- Accessibility: Free, widely used, student-friendly.

2. Ryff's Psychological Well-Being Scale (Short Version):

- Source: Ryff (1989), adapted by Seifert (2005).
- Purpose: Captures key aspects of well-being.
- Scoring: Sum items; higher = better well-being.
- Accessibility: Simplified for ease, no cost.

3. **Subjective Happiness Scale (SHS):**

- Source: Lyubomirsky & Lepper (1999).
- Purpose: Gauges overall happiness.
- Scoring: Average items; higher = happier.
- Accessibility: Public domain, minimal time.

4. **Gratitude Questionnaire-6 (GQ-6):**

- Source: McCullough et al. (2002).
- Purpose: Assesses gratitude levels.
- Scoring: Sum items (reverse some); higher = more grateful. Accessibility: Free, quick to complete.

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